the KJVD in Hitler's Germany,' he recounted.9 In Essen, he tossed anti-Nazi leaflets from the roof of the Althof department store near the city centre and formed an alliance with Catholic and Protestant youth groups, including the young members of the SPD-affiliated 'Friends of Nature' (the KPD's aversion to the SPD was abandoned after Hitler came to power).

Across Germany, tens of thousands of communists were sent to concentration camps such as Dachau near Munich where 5,200 anti-fascists were squeezed into prison huts. According to the Red Aid organisation, 5,000 communists were murdered before mid-1935, while 21,000 were sent for trial, and 19,000 were taken to execution sheds or slapped with lengthy prison terms. During this period, Honecker attended the Central Committee conference of the Communist Youth League in Amsterdam and the Antifascist Workers' Congress of Europe in Paris, organised by trade unions in Germany, Italy and Poland. Delegates called for Ernst Thälmann – still shackled in a Nazi prison – to be freed. 'Hitler's murder gang mean business against Comrade Thälmann, but the workers of the world can save him from these murderers,' British socialist Harry Pollitt declared. 'Let us just ask ourselves what it must mean to sit in a prison cell for over a year, never knowing which day might be the last.' From Paris, Honecker travelled to Basel, then made his way to Zurich, where he spent three weeks at a hotel near Lake Lucerne.

With the Saar preparing to hold a plebiscite on union with the Third Reich in January 1935, he joined the KPD's canvassing effort which urged residents to vote for the region to remain a League of Nations mandate territory. 'During those weeks we were on the move every day and on many evenings spoke in more than one location,' he remembered. 'We fought right up to the last minute.'

Yet, fighting the Nazi claim that the Saar was tied by blood to the German fatherland –turned out to be an uphill battle, made worse by Hitler's sabre-rattling propaganda minister, Joseph Goebbels, a club-footed loudmouth who whipped up a propaganda campaign. He dubbed communists 'the sworn enemy' of God, and found many believers, especially among the large Catholic community. Although the mood was increasingly hostile (many communist speakers were booed and hissed), Honecker fared well in